I've been shooting with iPhone for over a decade, across generations of its cameras, and I've always been fascinated by the technology underneath the photographs. For most of that time, increasingly clever computation has overcome the physical limitations of a smartphone. The iPhone 18 Pro takes a different turn: it brings the physical controls of a conventional camera into the equation.

Qutab Minar — 48MP Main, ƒ/1.48

Tiny carvings remain distinct across the illuminated stone while the evening sky stays remarkably clean.

The 48MP Main camera gets a new sensor and faster ƒ/1.48 aperture, alongside a new computational imaging pipeline that Apple says produces sharper, more detailed images. Equally impressive is the colour science: intensely orange illumination remains vivid without destroying the colour and texture of the sandstone.

I find the technology underneath this extraordinary: all that real-time computation, yet a photograph that doesn't scream processed.

Lattice — 4x Telephoto, manual focus

Here I deliberately focused through the dominant foreground lattice onto the geometry behind it — something autofocus instinctively wants to fight. I'm no longer asking the phone to decide what my subject is.

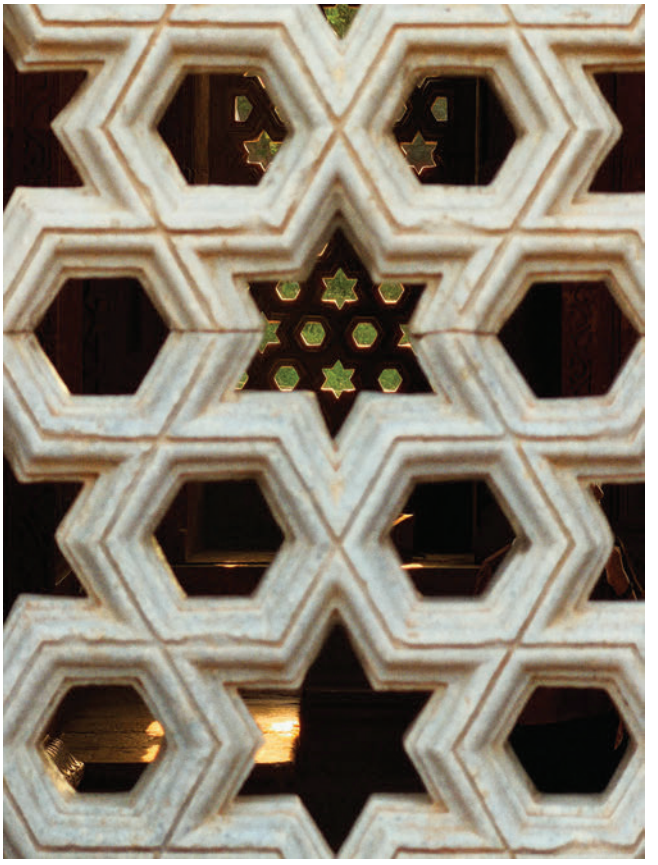
Photographic Styles is evolving too, with texture and adjustable grain joining colour and tone. Today grain is simply on or off; tomorrow, could we dial in exactly how much we want, have it respond organically to ISO, or choose between different grain structures? Styles is becoming far less about presets and far more about creative control.

Starburst — ƒ/4

This is where things get wonderfully mechanical. Six tiny, laser-cut aperture blades stopped down to ƒ/4 turn the sun breaking through the leaves into that spectacular starburst through real optical diffraction. I love the engineering absurdity of this: a physical iris, precisely moving microscopic blades, inside a pocketable phone.

And aperture is only half the story. Manual shutter-speed control opens up another set of possibilities: drag the shutter to turn traffic into streaks of colour, smooth moving water, or deliberately introduce motion blur.

Beyond all this, I think the biggest change is cultural. Maybe the iPhone 18 Pro's most exciting trick is making photography nerds of us all.





Courtesy of Joshua Karthik (@joshuakarthikr), a photographer, filmmaker, creative director, technology creator and co-founder of Stories by Joseph Radhik.